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ORIGINAL RESEARCH

Analyzing Differences Between Male and Female Leadership Styles, the Underrepresentation of Women in Leadership and the Negative Impacts it has.

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Abstract :

Research shows that men and women have different leadership styles. Women tend to be more democratic, while men lean towards being autocratic. However, there is no evidence to suggest that one style is more effective than the other. Women can be successful in political settings due to their empathy, confidence, and sensitivity to citizens' needs. Despite this, women are highly underrepresented in leadership positions, such as CEOs in Fortune 500 companies. Barriers like the "sticky floor" and "glass ceiling" limit women's advancement. This lack of representation has negative impacts, reducing role models for girls and limiting diverse perspectives. Solutions include raising awareness, implementing gender quotas, and introducing leadership and mentorship programs. It is important to address gender disparities and promote diversity in leadership roles.

Keywords : Coronavirus, Coronavirus disease 2019, Gender, Novel coronavirus, Pandemic, Severe acute respiratory syndrome coronavirus 2, emergency medicine, gender, gender disparities, physician leadership, salary, underrepresented minorities

Introduction :

Leadership can be defined, simply, as a process by which an individual exerts influence to structure behaviors and relationships of a team or group to be able to achieve a certain goal. To take the definition further, it is important to take into consideration the necessary qualities of an effective leader: understanding and achieving the goals of the group while taking into consideration needs, motivations, and best interests of the participants in an adaptable, flexible, and focused way. Although research does prove that men and women exert different leadership styles, there is no research showing that there is a significant difference between leadership effectiveness. (Paustian-Underdahl et al.) [1] Thus, raising questions regarding the severe underrepresentation of women in leadership positions.

This paper will analyze different leadership styles between men and women to advance knowledge regarding gender disparities in leadership positions, and offer solutions to resolve the issue [2].

Differences in leadership style:

There is a preconceived notion that the main difference between men and women in leadership is that women follow more interpersonal styles (people oriented: engage and inspire others to get things done), and men follow more task-oriented leadership styles (placing emphasis on structure/ plans to get things done).In contrast, researchers have observed a notable distinction between the two genders.

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Suggesting that women tend to display democratic tendencies, while men often lean towards autocratic tendencies [3]. Democratic leadership can be defined as encouraging participation by taking into consideration ideas, goals, values, beliefs, etc from the members of the team. Autocratic leadership can be defined as where the leader has complete control of the entire team and their goals (Eagly and Johnson). Even with these differences, recent studies indicate that in political settings, women actually tend to be more successful than men, not only in the United States, but also around the world. For example, when analyzing different policy responses in the face of the COVID-19 pandemic, researchers found that female leaders generally set lockdown policies earlier on in the pandemic, causing fewer COVID-19 related deaths (Garikipati and Kambhampati). Research suggests that women delivered policies with greater empathy and confidence, showed greater sensitivity to their citizens, and differed from men in the way they expressed themselves to their citizens (i.e. in speeches) (Sergent and Stajkovic). Further, as shown in Figure 1, which is a graph representing polling answers regarding what characteristics male versus female leaders are more likely to have (i.e. honesty, intelligence, hardworking, etc) [4]. The results of the poll show that the majority actually believes that female political leaders dominate male political leaders in every single one of those characteristics except for decisiveness. (Pew Research Center, 2008)

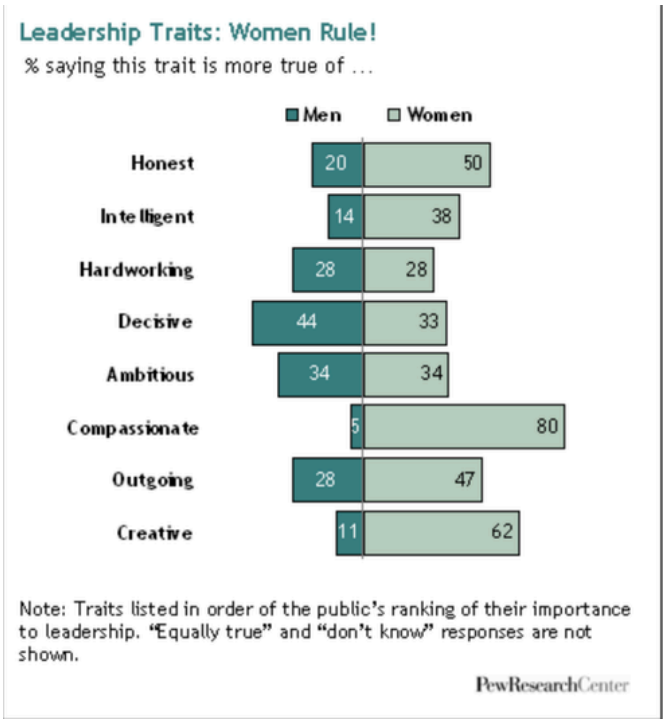

FIGURE 1 (Pew Research Center)

Gender Disparities in Leadership:

This, since it can be seen that there are differences between styles of leadership in gender, it is important to take into consideration the diminished opportunities women face in the attempt of rising up to higher positions: especially in the corporate pipeline, as shown in Figure 2. Although representation for women has increased overtime, the numbers by which they are increasing are significantly low. Further, it can be shown that out of the Fortune 500 companies, only 10% of the CEOs are women: equalling 447 male CEOs, and 53 female CEOs (Hinchliffe 2023) [5]. This research can help shed light on barriers women encounter such as the sticky floor effect and the glass ceiling. The two concepts, the sticky floor and the glass ceiling, work in tandem to impede the advancement of women into higher positions within an organization. The sticky floor effect confines women to lower ranks on the job scale, while the glass ceiling, sometimes referred to as the motherhood penalty, acts as an additional barrier, inhibiting their opportunities for promotion. (Hutchman) [6]. Occupational segregation (unequal distribution of individuals across a given setting), unconscious bias in hiring, bias in performance evaluations, lack of opportunities, and essentially barriers that limit upward mobility in organizations align with the sticky floor effect. Further, gendered expectations, stereotypes, gender pay gaps, lack of representation of women in leadership, and essentially larger, systemic factors barring higher female leadership roles that align with the glass ceiling effect [7].

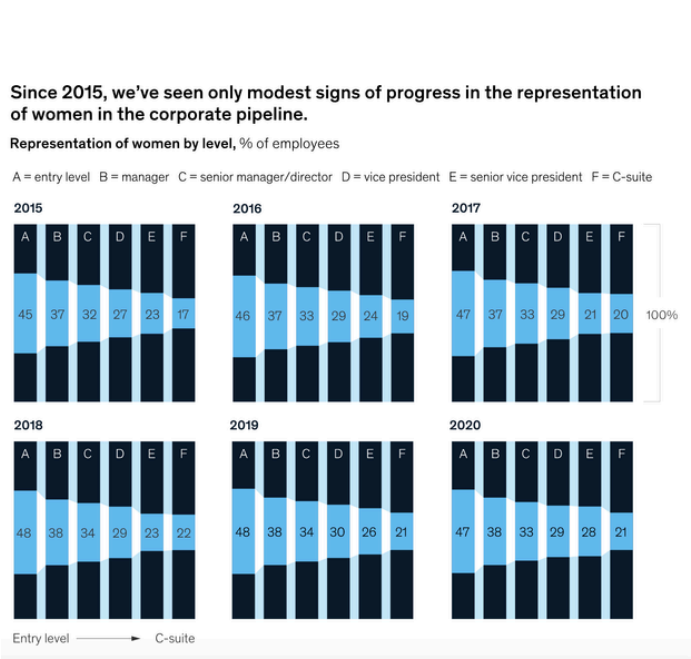

FIGURE 2: (McKinsey & Company (2020)

These disparities cause significant impairment for women in many different aspects. First, there is a diminished representation and role models for young girls looking into leadership roles. Many studies show that role models are extremely important for the inspiration and support of younger generations around the world, and the withdrawal of these role models are detrimental; causing young girls to get less encouraged to engage in leadership roles. For instance, it is said that 36% of women in leadership state role models were the precipitating factor to push them into leadership (Skorko). Further, the underrepresentation of women in leadership causes difficulty in women attempting to get their voices heard in their organization. This is because it is evident that women feel more comfortable sharing serious thoughts and ideas with other women and vice versa for men [8]. With the lack of female leadership, genuine female opinions regarding organizational change are not heard, and therefore not implemented; further catastrophizing the issue of gender disparities in society. Lastly, the emergence of the term, impostor syndrome, helps display the negative effects these gender disparities can have on the mental health of women. Impostor syndrome can be defined as a person feeling as though undeserving and incapable of achievements, which can not only be developed through consistent failure and decreased ability of promotion, but many highly successful women suffer from these effects [9,10]. Gender disparities in leadership not only negatively impact women, but it also affects society as a whole. For instance, an organization's failure to recruit female leaders can actually further reinforce gender stereotypes; by consistently putting men as leaders, and women as followers, the organization is displaying to everyone that they believe men are better as leaders [11]. Further, there is a major loss of diverse ideas. In an organization, it is important to recruit diverse. Persons, as they bring upon different experiences, ideas, and solutions. Without the use of female diverse ideas, society is failing to benefit from a multitude of potential advancements and prospective social change [12].

Discussion:

Many solutions have been developed to increase representation of women in leadership positions, however, it is crucial to have support for policy changes regarding gender disparities in the workplace. The encouragement of dismantling stereotypes and emphasizing the importance of support for policy changes can be two big precipitating factors for the diminishment of gender disparities. There are many ways this can be implemented: first, through awareness campaigns, where public knowledge regarding the Extent of the disparities women face in not only the workplace, but also in leadership positions is increased with the use of social media, public events, etc. Another solution for organizations can be to set a quota on the number of gender diverse employees that have been recruited, and to consistently check up on the data to ensure women are not getting held back in their positions due to gender differences. Further, implementing diversity programs that increase engagement and inclusion such as 1) leadership and mentorship programs/ schemes (increase representation of minority women though the implementation of diversity task forces) and 2) sponsorship programs (where a sponsor and protégé are paired to be able to put the protégé in powerful networks) are all efficient ways to work toward gender inclusion.

Conclusion:

The available evidence is clear: with the differences in leadership styles and characteristics between men and women, COVID-19 response statistics convey that women can make better leaders than men. This review highlights the severe underrepresentation of women in leadership roles; specifically those of higher positions and organizations, and raises awareness regarding the negative impacts gender disparities in leadership settings can have on not only women, but on society as a whole with the use of the analysis between the different leadership styles and characteristics between men and women.

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